

Heart Soup

Fiction

Nana Rosa always made soup when someone was sad.

She called it heart soup, though there was nothing unusual in the ingredients. It was just vegetables, stock, a handful of herbs and whatever was left in the fridge. But somehow, without fail, it was always exactly what was needed.

When ten-year-old Bea arrived at Nana Rosa's house after school, still red-eyed from crying, her grandmother didn't ask questions. She simply pointed at the kitchen chair – the one with the yellow cushion – and began to chop.

The knife moved steadily. Carrots, celery, a leek. The smell of onion filled the kitchen. Bea watched in silence.

"Was it Priya?" Nana Rosa asked, without turning round.

Bea looked up, startled. "How did you know?"

"Because she is the only one who makes you cry on a Monday."

Bea almost smiled at this. Almost.

The soup began to bubble. Nana Rosa added a pinch of something from an unlabelled jar.

Bea noticed it but didn't ask – there were certain things about Nana Rosa's kitchen that were better left as mysteries.

"She said I wasn't invited to her party," Bea said at last. "In front of everyone."

Nana Rosa was quiet for a moment. Then: "What did you do?"

"Nothing. I just walked away."

"Good," said Nana Rosa simply.

"Is it?" said Bea. "It didn't feel good. It felt terrible."

"Walking away when you want to fight is one of the bravest things a person can do," Nana Rosa said. She placed two bowls on the table and ladled the soup carefully. "And besides," she added, sitting down opposite Bea, "you are always invited here."

Bea looked at the bowl in front of her. The steam rose in a slow curl. She picked up the spoon.

It tasted, somehow, exactly like being home.